

Northwind Analytics Pvt. Ltd.

Employee Handbook — FY2026 Edition

This handbook is a test artifact created to exercise a Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) knowledge-base server. It intentionally contains multiple distinct policy sections with specific numbers, thresholds, and terminology so semantic search results are meaningfully distinguishable between topics.

1. Leave Policy

Northwind Analytics provides 24 days of paid annual leave per calendar year for all full-time employees, accrued at a rate of 2 days per completed month of service. New hires become eligible to take accrued leave after completing 90 days of employment, though leave begins accruing from the first day of joining.

In addition to annual leave, employees receive 12 days of paid sick leave per year, which does not require advance approval but must be reported to a manager before 10:00 AM on the day of absence. Sick leave exceeding 3 consecutive days requires a medical certificate.

Parental leave is provided as 26 weeks of paid leave for the primary caregiver and 2 weeks of paid leave for the secondary caregiver, in line with statutory requirements. Employees must notify HR at least 30 days before the expected start of parental leave.

Unused annual leave may be carried forward into the next calendar year up to a maximum of 10 days; any balance beyond that is forfeited on December 31st unless local law requires otherwise. Leave cannot be encashed except at the time of final settlement upon exit.

2. Expense and Reimbursement Policy

Employees may claim reimbursement for business-related expenses including client travel, client meals, software subscriptions required for work, and approved training courses. All claims must be submitted through the Expense Portal within 30 days of the expense being incurred, accompanied by an itemized receipt.

Domestic travel is reimbursed at actual cost for economy-class flights and 3-star or equivalent hotel accommodation, subject to a nightly cap of ■6,000 in metro cities and ■4,000 in non-metro cities. International travel requires pre-approval from a Director-level approver at least 2 weeks in advance.

Client meal expenses are capped at ■2,500 per person per meal. Alcohol is reimbursable only when entertaining external clients, and only up to 50% of the total bill. Personal meals during travel are reimbursed up to a daily per-diem of ■1,200.

Expense claims exceeding ■25,000 in a single submission require secondary approval from Finance in addition to the manager's approval. Claims submitted more than 90 days after the expense date will not be reimbursed except in documented exceptional circumstances.

3. Remote Work Policy

Northwind Analytics operates a hybrid work model. Employees are expected to work from the office a minimum of 3 days per week, with Tuesday and Thursday designated as mandatory in-office collaboration days for all teams.

Fully remote work arrangements may be approved on a case-by-case basis for roles that do not require regular in-person collaboration, subject to written approval from both the employee's manager and the People Operations team. Fully remote employees must maintain a stable internet connection of at least 50 Mbps and be available during core hours of 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM in their local time zone.

Employees working remotely for more than 2 consecutive weeks from a location outside their registered city (a 'workation') must inform HR at least 5 business days in advance and confirm continued availability during standard working hours.

The company provides a one-time home office setup allowance of ■15,000 for employees on an approved fully-remote arrangement, covering items such as a monitor, chair, or desk.

4. Code of Conduct

All employees are expected to act with integrity, honesty, and respect in every interaction with colleagues, clients, and partners. Harassment, discrimination, or retaliation of any kind will not be tolerated and should be reported immediately to HR or through the confidential ethics hotline.

Conflicts of interest — including outside employment, financial interests in vendors or competitors, or close personal relationships with direct reports — must be disclosed to HR in writing within 15 days of the conflict arising.

Confidential company and client information must not be shared outside the organization, including on personal social media accounts, without explicit written authorization from the Legal team. This obligation survives termination of employment.

Violations of the Code of Conduct are handled through a progressive disciplinary process: verbal warning, written warning, final written warning, and termination — except in cases of gross misconduct, which may result in immediate termination.

5. IT and Data Security Policy

All company laptops must have disk encryption and endpoint protection software enabled at all times. Employees must not disable these tools under any circumstances; doing so will trigger an automated alert to the Security team.

Passwords for company systems must be at least 14 characters long, rotated every 90 days, and must not be reused across the last 10 passwords. Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all systems handling client data.

Client data must never be downloaded to personal devices or personal cloud storage accounts (e.g. personal Google Drive or Dropbox). All client data processing must occur within company-approved, audited environments only.

Any suspected security incident — including a lost device, phishing attempt, or unauthorized access — must be reported to security@northwindanalytics.example within 1 hour of discovery. Delayed reporting beyond 24 hours may result in disciplinary action.

6. Employee Benefits

Northwind Analytics provides group health insurance covering the employee, spouse, and up to 2 dependent children, with a sum insured of ■5,00,000 per family per year. Coverage begins on the employee's date of joining with no waiting period.

Employees are enrolled in the company provident fund at a contribution rate of 12% of basic salary, matched equally by the company. Voluntary additional contributions up to 20% of basic salary are permitted.

A learning and development allowance of ■40,000 per year is available for courses, certifications, and conference attendance directly relevant to the employee's role, subject to manager approval.

Employees are eligible for an annual wellness reimbursement of up to ■10,000 covering gym memberships, fitness classes, or mental health counseling sessions.

7. Onboarding Process

New employees receive their laptop and system access credentials on Day 1. IT provisioning requests must be submitted by HR at least 3 business days before the employee's start date to ensure equipment is ready.

The first two weeks follow a structured onboarding plan covering company orientation, team introductions, tool training, and role-specific shadowing. A designated onboarding buddy is assigned to every new hire for the first 30 days.

A 30-60-90 day check-in cycle is conducted by the hiring manager to review progress, set goals, and surface any blockers. The probation period is 90 days, at the end of which confirmation of employment is reviewed by the manager and HR jointly.

8. Performance Review Process

Formal performance reviews are conducted twice a year, in April and October. Each cycle includes a self-assessment, manager assessment, and peer feedback from at least 2 colleagues nominated by the employee.

Ratings are given on a 5-point scale, and employees rated 4 or above are eligible for the annual merit increase and bonus pool. Employees rated below 2 for two consecutive cycles are placed on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) with a 60-day review window.

Promotion decisions are made once a year, following the October review cycle, and require endorsement from the employee's manager plus one skip-level approver.